

J A C Q U E S D U P L E S S I S

Engineering Manifesto

What I believe. What I bring. What I would build.

We have great, talented people at Alpha. And a well-established Engineering department. But the lack of leadership over the last few months have left tangible gaps, not only in direction, but also in people management, getting answers for questions and process. So far I believe that I have been taking on a lot of the responsibilities that the role would entail regardless.

My vision for the Engineering department is a simple one – cohesion. Currently we are scattered physically across the world, but I think also mentally.

I believe we should focus on our values, and double down on what makes working at Alpha great. These are the things I'd like to focus on if I am appointed as Head of Engineering:

01. MISSION-FIRST ENGINEERING

Technology is not the product. We serve a mission first. All that we do needs to fit into our 2033 Vision for Alpha and the things we build should enable that. By cultivating the right values in our teams, leading by example and rewarding the right things we will all feel the value of what we build personally.

That is also why my first suggestion would be to get the Engineers, the builders more exposure to the mission and to be more involved across departments.

02. PEOPLE OVER PROCESS

We've got a lot of talented people. We need to cultivate trust within our teams and across teams. My focus would be to cultivate psychological safety within the teams and build that inward trust. The aim of this would be to strengthen collaboration and to enable everyone to reach out to domain experts within our stack.

03. SIMPLICITY AS A STRATEGY

Our systems are complex. We have lots of technical debt and we operate within a very strange geographical and legal landscape. So far our tech has reflected this – as the theory by Jeff Winters. But we can double down on making things less complex. We've seen this with our approach to the Whatsapp Course Registration solution.

This means we'll make some trade-offs. And perhaps we'll have to break a few habits and established processes.

04. MOVE FAST WITH AI

AI isn't going away. We've adopted it into our dev workflows already and have sped up because of it. AI isn't going away, it is speeding up and getting better. We should not fear it, and I don't believe it means the end of engineering either. We currently lack a proper AI use policy, and engineers can use it as they see fit. We have stated some guidelines, mainly for safety reasons, like not inputting any actual user data into it or giving direct access to production databases, etc.

My aim is to define this policy and to really be able to benefit from the use of AI. We can build things extremely fast, and in conjunction with my third ideal, we will be able to build many more projects than what we currently do.

05. FIX THINGS PROPERLY – SHINE IN EXCELLENCE

We should not settle for bugs, tech debt, limitations or be scared away by complexity and brittle legacy code. We want to build things that serve a mission so we need to fix what we have properly. If we have to spend time detangling a system we should. We should not settle for hacks or workarounds and we should not settle for half measures. We have the skills to solve our users and our NAOs' problems properly and we should. We should, as a department, spend more time on proper support and making sure that all our engineers have sufficient understanding of the systems that they deal with.

Jacques du Plessis